

GOING NOWHERE

- 1 SEPTEMBER 11, 2007**
Mukherjee tells Left deal is only about nuclear energy.
- 2 SEPTEMBER 19, 2007**
Left says deal will boost strategic ties with the US.
- 3 OCTOBER 5, 2007**
Left gives a seven-point note highlighting its objections.
- 4 OCTOBER 9, 2007**
Left hardens stance, asks UPA to freeze the deal.
- 5 OCTOBER 22, 2007**
UPA says Hyde Act isn't binding, Left disagrees.
- 6 NOVEMBER 16, 2007**
Left allows the UPA to negotiate with the IAEA.
- 7 MARCH 17, 2008**
Left shown highlights of IAEA draft. Deadlock continues.
- 8 MAY 6, 2008**
UPA pleads time running out, Left remains adamant.
- 9 MAY 28, 2008**
Meeting postponed to June 18 and deferred again.

NSG member countries. Then the deal goes before the US Congress which has to okay the 123 Agreement to change its domestic laws to allow civil nuclear trade between the US and India. Although the US State Department deputy spokesperson Tom Casey has said that the US will make every effort to push the deal till January 20, the day the new President assumes office, diplomatic sources have told INDIA TODAY that time is running out and if the deal is not presented before the US Congress by August, it will be effectively dead. This deadline was reiterated by US Ambassador David C. Mulford on June 16 when he was quizzed by senior PMO officials, who also wanted to know if the NSG would give the nod 'immediately' in case the Government managed to get the deal



past the IAEA next month.

Despite being told that time is running out, the Left is in no mood to compromise. After the meeting was postponed, the Left issued a statement saying that it would not allow UPA to go to the IAEA. It has complained that since it has not been shown the draft IAEA agreement, it cannot give its approval. The communists have also decided to brief the UPA allies about their opposition to the deal. Karat has already met DMK's T.R. Baalu in this regard.

For some inexplicable reason, the Government still believes it can push the deal through. "The deal is not dead. Otherwise why would the meeting be postponed and not cancelled?" said Union Minister Kapil Sibal. It is a refrain he has repeated before. But of late his words sound less and less convincing. It is not just the Left, even the other UPA allies have made it clear that while they have no ideological objection to the deal, they are not willing to risk the Government to secure this particular milestone on Manmohan Singh's bio-data. Moreover, with rising prices and inflation dominating the headlines, even Manmohan's own colleagues say this is not a good time to test the electorate.

UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi agrees with the prime minister that the deal would be good for India. She has tried to sell the deal in politically-cor-

DEADLOCK: Mukherjee (right) and Yechury reach an impasse

rect terms, explaining that it would help in solving the country's energy crisis. But at the same time she does not seem ready to risk the Government for the deal. And without Sonia's go-ahead, the prime minister does not have the political clout to push through what is fast becoming his pet project. He does not even have the freedom for a political martyrdom on the issue.

As a result, Manmohan's term will not be remembered for what he achieved but rather for what he tried to achieve. Ever since his infamous 'so be it' ultimatum to the Left in August last year, UPA has been tottering in newspaper headlines. Whether it is a good budget, the loan waiver, or the extension of the employment guarantee scheme, all these efforts are being seen as sops on the eve of an inevitable general election.

Every prime minister has a dream. His personal tryst with greatness that he adds to the larger agenda of governance. For Atal Bihari Vajpayee, it was Pokhran II; Rajiv Gandhi ushered in the computer era; Narasimha Rao liberalised the economy; Manmohan wants to build his legacy on the nuclear deal. Unfortunately, far from becoming the flagship of his Government, it runs the risk of degenerating into a mere footnote of failure. **with Shafi Rahman**